

In 2023, Sudharsan scored 116 runs from two matches at an average of 38.66. Last year, the southpaw racked up 165 runs from three games with a century against Nottinghamshire at Trent Bridge in Nottingham.

Meanwhile, Nair, back in the Indian team after seven years, began with a double century for India A against England Lions. A consistent performer for Vidarbha, he scored 863 runs in nine Ranji games in the 2024-25 season, and 779 in eight Vijay Hazare matches, with nine centuries across formats.

The composure Nair showed against the England Lions wasn't accidental. It reflected the seasoning that comes from a proper County grind. Across two seasons with Northamptonshire (2023-24), Nair played 10 Championship matches and averaged 56.61.

Still, the real test is whether this domestic and A-team form can translate into performances in a long, high-stakes series abroad.



THE SERIES IS INDIA'S FIRST SINCE THE RETIREMENTS OF ROHIT SHARMA, R ASHWIN AND VIRAT KOHLI FROM TEST CRICKET, AND MOHAMMED SHAMI IS ALSO MISSING FROM THE SQUAD



Recent red-ball struggles

India's recent form in Tests has been patchy. A shock whitewash at home against New Zealand was followed by a 1-3 defeat in Australia.

While Kohli and Rohit struggled across both series, others didn't step up either.

Pant was India's top scorer against New Zealand with 261 runs at 43.50. Jaiswal managed 190 at 31.66; Sarfaraz Khan, 171 at 28.50.

India's tour of Australia offered flashes of promise — Jaiswal's 391 runs, centuries from Rahul and Nitish



Kumar Reddy — but the batting unit failed to sustain pressure or seize key moments. Pant had a quiet outing and a poor IPL as LSG captain. Yet, as vice-captain, he is likely to start. But there's competition. Dhruv Jurel, who has proven his mettle with 227 runs from four innings for India A against England Lions.

Elevated: Rishabh Pant has been named vice-captain of the 18-member squad for the England Tests — a nod to his red-ball experience in English conditions and growing leadership stature. K. MURALIKUMAR